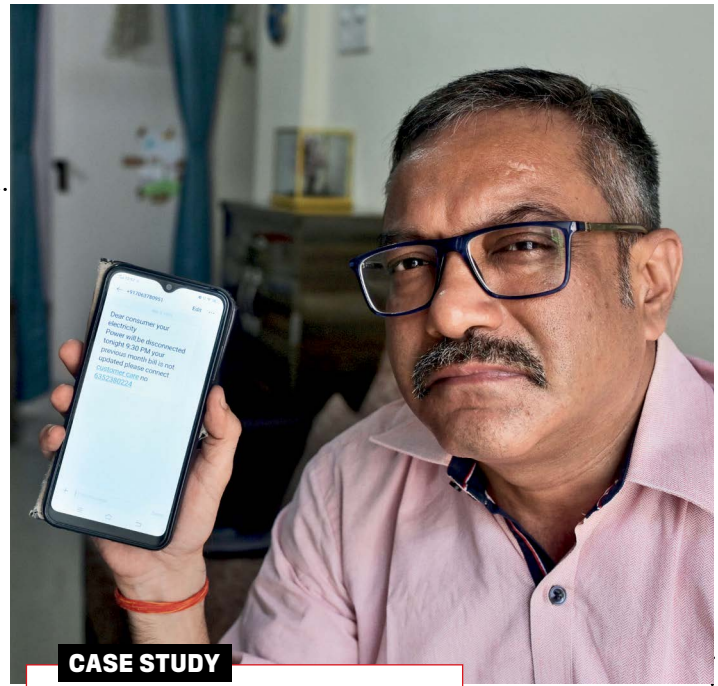


MILIND SHELTE

CASE STUDY

MUMBAI

SHARDUL NAUTIYAL, 45

Journalist

Sum lost: **Rs 2.6 lakh**

Victim of: **Phishing**

High Price for Power

On March 4, Nautiyal's wife received an SMS from an unknown number, asking her to update their debit card details to pay the electricity bill. Since her number was not registered with the power utility, the couple dismissed the message. Next day, they got a call. The caller asked Nautiyal to pay Rs 10 using his power utility payment gateway. Then, he was told the payment had failed and the "update" was unsuccessful and that he needed to download an app. Falling for the ruse, Nautiyal did as he was told and lost Rs 2.6 lakh from two accounts in just 11 minutes. Nautiyal approached both the banks and the police, but all he has been able to find out is that his money was withdrawn the same day from an ATM in West Bengal. The banks have refused to reimburse the money. ■

-Amitabh Srivastava

WHO IS A CYBERCRIMINAL?

He could well be your average Joe. A matriculate or a law graduate or a chartered accountancy student, if you will. A lone wolf or part of a multi-layered syndicate, each reporting to the next level, with nary a clue about the final beneficiary. Each such level gets a fixed cut, usually 10 per cent of the defrauded amount. He probably learns his craft at any one of the "training centres" thriving across the country. Offering crash courses in cybercrime, the costs range from Rs 10,000 to Rs 15,000, depending on the training module. Phishing and reselling site frauds are the cheapest, sextortion courses the most expensive and the longest in duration. Jamtara perhaps showed the way, but mini Kota factories have sprung up across villages in Rajasthan and Haryana. A few aspirants are even going overseas, like the group from Ahmedabad that the Gujarat police said went to Nigeria for some valuable lessons in cyber fraud.

Local economies are prospering too. Farmers in Rajasthan are reported to be renting fields to cyber criminals in the Aravalli foothills to carry out their activities; roads in Jamtara are lined with mobile phone halls where youth hang out during 'working hours'. Cutting-edge technology is being used to execute increasingly sophisticated crimes. Artificial Intelligence has changed the game significantly, facilitating all manner of cloning, from profile pictures to websites to people's voices. Others are manipulating biometrics, making Aadhaar cards a conduit for fraud. "Cybercrime is an evolving crime," says Triveni Singh, superintendent of police, cybercrime, UP. "As new technologies such as AI emerge, cyber criminals are using them without fear as it is very difficult to catch them." So much so that a poorly-trained and ill-equipped police force is finding it difficult to keep up, and existing laws are inadequate to act as deterrents.

Most cybercrime in India relates to online financial fraud, as the FCRF findings show (see *Cybercrime Trends*). UPI frauds were the highest at 47.3 per cent, followed by debit/ credit card/ SIM swap (11.3 per cent) and internet banking-related frauds (9.3 per cent). Online and social media-related crime accounted for 12 per cent, and hacking (1.2 per cent), cyber trafficking (0.1 per cent), ransomware (0.1 per cent), cryptocurrency frauds (0.2 per cent), cyber terrorism (0.2 per cent) and deepfake crimes (0.1 per cent) made up the rest.

Given this surge in cybercrime, growing with utter impunity, the INDIA TODAY bureau sought out a cross-section of victims to discuss some of the ways in which cyber crooks are hoodwinking